

Chapter 41-2

Liang Shi slowly closed her eyes.

What followed was another long, heavy dream from which she couldn't wake.

The dream was filled with the same dark tones as always, a cramped room where not even a ray of sunlight could penetrate, with only a night lamp hanging on the wall.

The light was dim, and a little girl in the room crouched in the corner.

Qi Tai Tai walked in wearing a blue-green qipao¹ that would faintly glow under the dark lighting. She was smiling, but it was a smile that made one's scalp tingle.

Behind her followed a little girl. Qi Tai Tai called to her, "Jiao Jiao, aren't you the best at teaching little children?"

Qi Tai Tai lit a cigarette in this sunless room, "Go teach little sister how she should behave at home from now on."

The little girl called Qi Jiao was wearing a princess dress, with a large gash on her forehead and bruises at the corner of her mouth. She slowly walked over, crouched down to be at eye level with the little girl in the corner, "You must listen to Mama, okay? Little children who don't listen to Mama will get beaten."

Her voice was very much like the childish voices in horror movies.

Combined with the enclosed space, one could even hear the echo.

There was no light in her eyes, only numbness and barely detectable fear.

Qi Tai Tai exhaled a ring of smoke, the blue-gray smoke dispersing before her eyes.

She stood up, her high heels clicking against the cement floor, each sound like stepping on someone's heart, as if wantonly trampling on a person's heart.

Then she looked down at Qi Jiao from above, "Jiao Jiao, make little sister speak."

Qi Jiao then said, "You speak, say that you will listen to Mama."

The little girl said, "I've always listened to Mama very well. I want to go home, I don't want to stay here."

Qi Tai Tai chuckled lightly, "But your mama told you to stay here. She said you don't listen, oh."

As she spoke, she crouched down, "Didn't you break your mama's lipstick last time?"

The little girl nodded in terror, "But I didn't mean to, I already apologized to Mama."

"Does apologizing mean you should be forgiven?" Qi Tai Tai smiled, "Just like my Jiao Jiao."

"Jiao Jiao, didn't Mama tell you to make little sister listen to you? But why is she still talking back to me?" Qi Tai Tai said.

Qi Jiao immediately said, "Mama, I'm sorry, I was wrong."

"But does 'sorry' always get you 'it's okay'?" Qi Tai Tai said, then suddenly pressed the still-burning cigarette butt onto Qi Jiao's princess dress. The air immediately filled with the smell of burning fabric. Qi Jiao was in so much pain that tears streamed down, wanting to cry out loud but forcibly holding it in. She knelt on the ground, "Mama, I'm sorry."

"I should be the one saying sorry to you." Qi Tai Tai said, "Mama's Jiao Jiao, I'm sorry. Can you tell me 'it's okay'?"

"Mama, it's... it's okay." Qi Jiao said through her sobs.

"Jiao Jiao is so strong, why would she cry?" Qi Tai Tai said, once again pressing the still-unextinguished cigarette butt toward the little girl.

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The little girl burst into loud wails.

"I want to go home." the little girl said.

But Qi Tai Tai smiled, "After a while you won't want to anymore."

That voice was like a demon's whisper: "Once you become well-behaved, you can go home."

Footnotes: ¹ Qipao - A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, typically form-fitting with a high collar and side slits